

"There in the mist,
enormous, majestic,
silent, and terrible, stood
the Great Wall of China ..."

—W. Somerset Maugham, author (1874-1965)

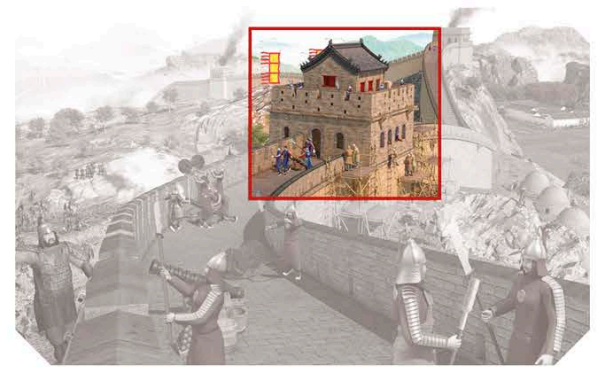
It rains a lot in China, so roofs always hang out a long way over walls, to protect them from dampness.

These openings are known as loopholes. Guards can drop rocks and grenades or fire arrows from them.

The Ming Wall and towers were mostly built by the guards themselves, with some help from skilled builders and craftsmen.

Windows give ventilation to stop the food inside the tower going moldy or gunpowder getting damp. A walled corridor helps keep things dry when it rains.

Barrels of gunpowder are kept locked in the tower because it is such a valuable and dangerous substance.



MONGOL ATTACKERS



The Great Wall was built to defend China from attacks by the Mongols. Under Genghis Khan the Mongols had conquered much of Asia and parts of Europe in the 1200s. By the 1500s they were less powerful, but still fearsome warriors, famed for their horse-riding and archery skills.

"Reclining moon" glaives have long, curving blades.

Triple-bladed pole-arms like this are called halberds.

Weapons of war

Each tower held a collection of swords, called *jian*; spears; and long, stabbing weapons called pole-arms or glaives. They came in all shapes and sizes but all had the same purpose: to allow the user to fight their enemy from a safe distance.

